What Can a Knower Claim?

Name _____

Group _____

KNOWLEDGE QUESTION

To what extent does what counts as historical knowledge depend on who is asked, and who does the asking?

For each part of today's activity, **talk** through the three questions with your group. Then **write one knowledge claim**. Your claim should be about knowledge, not about the *Titanic*: what does this part show about who is asked, and who does the asking?

1 The first reports

15 APRIL 1912

MISLED? **Why were readers misled?** The papers' main source was White Star, the company that owned the ship. What did White Star have to lose if the news was bad? Four papers in four cities ran the same story. Did any of them have a source of its own?

MORE ACCURATE? **What made the story more accurate?** What changed on the evening of 18 April, when *Carpathia* docked with the survivors?

CAN WE KNOW? **Can we know, and did anyone on 15 April?** What would a reader that day have needed before trusting the story?

YOUR CLAIM — *about knowledge, not the Titanic*

The first reports show that…

2 Did the ship break in two?

THE INQUIRIES, 1912 · THE WRECK, 1985

MISLED? **Why were knowers misled?** London's finding rested on one answer, from Lightoller, White Star's most senior surviving officer, to a lawyer for the Board of Trade, the body that had approved the ship as fit to sail. What did each of them have at stake? Careful: Symons and Osman also worked for White Star, and they said she broke.

MORE ACCURATE? **What made it more accurate?** Most witnesses in London were never asked whether she broke. Crew and passengers in different lifeboats, many of them strangers to each other, said she did. What would asking all of them have added? Then what happened in 1985?

CAN WE KNOW? **Can we know, and did anyone in 1912?** Could any number of witnesses have made a knower certain?

YOUR CLAIM — *about knowledge, not the Titanic*

The British inquiry shows that…

3 The shots

THREE QUESTIONS, NOT ONE

MISLED? **Why were knowers misled?** Daly told a doctor, then a newspaper, then a court. Rheims told his wife, then a lawyer under oath. Which telling went furthest each time, and who was listening?

MORE ACCURATE? **What made it more accurate?** Lowe admitted under oath that he fired. What did he have to lose by saying it? What does that do to how far you trust him?

CAN WE KNOW? **Can we know, and did anyone ever?** Were shots fired at all? Were they fired at people? Did an officer shoot himself? A pistol shot on an open deck leaves nothing the wreck could show. Which of the three can we know, and what could still change the others?

YOUR CLAIM *about knowledge, not the Titanic*

The accounts of the shots show that…

4 Panic, or order?

WHERE AND WHEN

MISLED? **Why were knowers misled?** Washington's report said that, "except in isolated instances, there was no panic." Beesley wrote that "no signs of alarm were exhibited by any one." Where was he, and when did he leave the ship? London called three passengers to give evidence, all of them first class, and then found that third-class passengers "were not unfairly treated."

MORE ACCURATE? **What made it more accurate?** Asking where and when each witness was. In Washington, Buckley and Abelseth, both third class, testified. Dodge, first class, says the panic came later. How can Dodge and Beesley both be telling the truth?

CAN WE KNOW? **Can we know?** Did anyone see the whole ship? What can a knower say, and how sure can they be?

YOUR CLAIM *about knowledge, not the Titanic*

The panic witnesses show that…

BRING IT TOGETHER

Read your four claims. For each one, look for a break: **when, for whom, or for which part does it stop being true?** Which claims, if any, hold without a break? Which, if any, run into something no knower could ever know? Then use at least two of your claims to answer the knowledge question.